



Theatre trail: The route to the cricket grounds is lined with another of London's great passions, as billboards for blockbuster stage productions turn an ordinary commute into a cultural tour.

announcing her retirement from international cricket. The Test against India would be her last match for England. At one stage, she breaks down.

A few days earlier, her captain, Nat Sciver-Brunt, had also cried while addressing the media after losing to Australia in the final. She, however, said this would not be her last World Cup.

The World Cup marked the end of the international careers of three fabulous New Zealand cricketers: Sophie Devine, Suzie Bates and Lea Tahuhu, who served their team for a decade and a half. They will be missed. And you cannot help but think of Devine's terrific sense of humour. You remember one incident:

At the Women's T20 Challenge, the precursor to the WPL, in Jaipur some years ago, Smriti Mandhana, the Trailblazers captain who was batting with her usual flourish, required some help with her shoelaces. Supernovas fielder Anuja Patil offered to help.

Her teammate Devine suggested to Anuja: "One way of getting her out would be to tie both the shoes together."

The World Cup was a forgettable one for New Zealand. But Devine, Bates and Tahuhu are all World Cup winners nevertheless: the Kiwis were the champions in the UAE two years ago.

While travelling on London's famous tube, the underground railway network that ensures the great city moves along the right track, you can't escape the

advertisements for theatre productions. Lavish musicals, intense dramas and stage versions of popular films like *The Devil Wears Prada* and *To Kill a Mockingbird* are currently playing. The last time you were in London, for the Global Chess League, you watched Agatha Christie's *The Mousetrap*, the world's longest-running play: it has been performed since 1952.

Talking of crime fiction, of which Christie is the undisputed queen, you are reminded of the greatest detective of them all, Sherlock Holmes, of course, while riding the tube. Baker Street station is near Lord's. 221 Baker Street is, of course, Holmes's fictional address.

And there is also women's cricket on the tube's billboards. The MCC's campaign features Heather Knight. The England batter is also on bus stops and at Lord's, where there is a huge poster of her. She may have seen it when she arrived to train and then play the Test.

At London's other famous cricket ground, the Oval, there is a gate named after Sciver-Brunt.



Growing up in a small Kerala town, radio was your window to international cricket, especially the BBC World Service. Test Match Special used to broadcast ball-by-ball commentary on shortwave radio. You can still remember the voices of great commentators like Christopher Martin-Jenkins, Don Mosey, Brian Johnston, Henry Blofeld, Tony Cozier, Trevor Bailey and Fred Trueman.

Those wet, cold evenings spent listening to the BBC in Kalpetta (Wayanad) come to mind when you enter Lord's, the Oval, Edgbaston, Old Trafford and Headingley. They return, too, when you walk past BBC Yorkshire, which is just a few 100 metres from your hotel in Leeds. A friendly journalist working at the BBC station, Nasser Hanif, is covering India's match against the Netherlands at Headingley. He gives you a tour of BBC Yorkshire.

While waiting to board one of those excellent long-distance buses to London, you watch, fascinated, as a wheelchair-bound young man is helped onto the bus using the manual ramp operated by the bus driver. An elderly woman thanks you for lending a helping hand. The young man is her grandson, and he has undergone surgery on his Achilles tendon. "He is a two-time World champion you know," she tells you.

Long-jumper Karim Chan (pic, left) missed out on bronze at the 2024 Paralympics in Paris. His World titles came in the junior category.